

**From “Problem Student” to Contextual Learner:
Deconstructing Bias Toward Neurodivergent
and CLD Students Through Practicum Observation**

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Deconstructing Bias — Reflective Paper

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This paper interrogates a bias I carry into classroom practice: the reflex to read neurodivergent and culturally and linguistically diverse (CLD) students through a compliance-and-deficit lens. In my practicum, that reflex surfaces as an automatic story—if a student is loud, impulsive, emotionally escalated, or “not listening,” they must be choosing to be disrespectful or disruptive. To examine that story, I draw on in-person classroom interactions from my elementary practicum placement during spring 2026: time-stamped, verbatim observation records from lessons and mentor feedback conversations, and one course seminar discussion on linguistic justice. Throughout this paper, I refer to these materials as Evidence Sets E1–E4 and Journal Artifacts J1–J3.

The bias under investigation is the “*problem student*” stereotype as it attaches to difference—difference in regulation (frequently read through a disability and neurodivergence lens) and difference in language and discourse (frequently read through a cultural and linguistic background lens). My guiding question is: *How do my practicum observations of neurodivergent and CLD students—especially students positioned as “problematic”—challenge the assumption that disruption is a fixed trait, and what shifts when adults respond relationally rather than punitively?*

In a course roundtable, I named the interpretive move I am trying to practice: that schools often read “visible frustration, noise avoidance or emotional escalation” as “*defiance rather than as evidence*” of confusion, stress, and unmet instructional needs (J3). That reframe anchors the central claim of this paper: what gets labeled “behavior” is often communication—a *contextual response to unclear expectations, cognitive overload, linguistic mismatch, or unmet regulation needs*. When conditions shift through relationship, co-regulation, and more linguistically just participation norms, students’ engagement shifts too, surfacing competence and brilliance that deficit narratives erase.

Autobiographical Grounding: Naming the Bias

This paper is not written from a neutral standpoint. I write as a Dominican-American student teacher who, only a year ago, learned for the first time that I am neurodivergent—and who is still working out what that means for who I have always been. Growing up in a Dominican cultural context, neurodivergence is not a category that exists in any generative way: you are either smart or you are not, capable or you are not. The cognitive and emotional variation that neurodivergence actually describes gets read through a moral lens instead of a neurological one. I spent my childhood performing through the extremes—*brilliant one month, invisible the next*—building coping mechanisms in silence, without knowing that is what they were, and without ever feeling permitted to name difficulty as real.

That is the specific origin of the bias this paper examines. The reflex to read a dysregulated student as *choosing* disruption is, in part, the reflex I was trained to turn on myself. Choosing to focus this assignment on neurodivergent and CLD students was therefore not a convenient selection—it was a personal one. These are not abstract subjects to me; they are the students whose experiences I have been quietly decoding in myself for the past year. Observing them closely is also, inevitably, a way of finally seeing what I could not name as a child.

Talusan (2022) frames identity-conscious practice as the ongoing work of noticing which assumptions we carry and how they shape what we see in students. That framing resonates directly. Moving through institutions that treated culture, language, disability, and gender variance as deficits rather than as sources of insight and resilience, I learned early that Dominican heritage, first-generation class position, ADHD, chronic illness, and CLD experience interlock rather than compete (J1). That history makes me protective of neurodivergent and CLD students—but it does not automatically shield me from replicating the same harm. Under pressure, the pull toward control is real and familiar, and I have had to name, in writing, the fear that schooling systems can “say equity” while still rewarding compliance (J2). This paper is one attempt to practice a different reflex: to pause, ask what a behavior is communicating, and build conditions where more students can be seen as fully human learners—including the student I once was.

Observation Context

The evidence base for this paper draws from my elementary practicum placement in spring 2026 and one professional learning discussion. Each evidence set is introduced below.

Evidence Set E1 is a grade 5 media and technology lesson in which students created short GIF videos on their Chromebooks—a self-paced, high-sensory task with unfamiliar software and a loud, busy room. A focal student (pseudonym *Student M*) escalated during the lesson and was publicly framed as “*screaming*” and “*yelling*” until a second adult offered him a purposeful role and named his competence directly, producing an immediate shift in engagement. The contrast between those adult moves—control versus invitation—is the primary analytical site for this paper.

Evidence Set E2 is a grade 2 robotics and routines block in which a student whose responses did not fit the expected pattern was publicly told he was “*doing weird stuff*” and “*ruining this for your whole class*,” then repositioned by that same adult minutes later as someone capable and needed: “*You’re smart, you can help them*.” That rapid oscillation between deficit framing and asset framing, directed at the same child within the same lesson, makes this record analytically useful for examining how the “*problem student*” category is produced and dissolved through language.

Evidence Set E3 is a mentor feedback conversation reflecting on years of relational investment with *Student M*—learning his triggers, offering predictability, and co-regulating before escalation. My mentor noted that he “*is used to people just yelling at him all day*,” reframing the observations in E1 as the outcome of sustained relational work rather than spontaneous compliance.

Evidence Set E4 is a professional learning discussion in which participants examined how dominant norms of silence, speed, and standardized speech define legitimate participation in schools, and how CLD students are systematically misread when those norms go unquestioned—including in computer science classrooms that invite multilingual reasoning or foreclose it.

Journal Artifacts J1–J3 are reflective writing that surface the autobiographical thread running through the analysis: how my own positionality as a neurodivergent, multilingual student teacher shapes what I notice, what I question, and what I want to do differently.

Myth vs. Reality: Core Analysis

The myth. Neurodivergent and CLD students become “*problem students*” because they are naturally disruptive, disrespectful, or unwilling to learn. This myth rests on two interlocking assumptions: (1) silence and compliance equal learning, and (2) deviation from dominant behavioral and linguistic norms signals character deficit.

DisCrit (Annamma et al., 2013) and Flynn’s (2024) affirmative non-tragedy model help name why this is not a neutral interpretive mistake: deficit framings of difference become justifications for control rather than support, shaping students’ trajectories in compounding ways. The linguistic justice seminar (E4) extended this insight—dominant participation norms harm CLD students when schools treat silence, speed, and standardized speech as the only legitimate channels for learning.

The reality. Across the practicum observation records (E1–E3), the “*problem student*” category is not discovered—it is produced, moment by moment, through adult talk, task design, and the presence or absence of relationship. In the grade 5 media lesson (E1), adults sometimes framed *Student M*’s body and voice as problems to suppress through public compliance demands. Yet, the same record captures a different set of moves that changed what was possible: a second adult invited *Student M* into a purposeful helper role, reinforced specific success rather than shame, and later reflected, “I’m actually so surprised how how [sic] smart he is” (E1). The student’s competence was not newly created—it was newly *recognized* once conditions supported regulation and re-entry.

The mentor feedback conversation makes this relational frame explicit. My mentor described how connection and patience changed *Student M*’s school day, and I named triggers and cognitive load rather than willfulness as the more useful lens for understanding escalation (E3). The linguistic justice discussion (E4) extends the same logic to CLD students: when schools equate learning with silence and standardized speech, difference is easily—and consequentially—misread as disrespect.

Assets and Funds of Knowledge

Reading the same observations through an asset lens reveals what the “*problem student*” story obscures. Gonzalez, Moll, and Amanti (2005) argue that learners bring funds of knowledge from home and community that schools routinely fail to recognize. In the practicum records, those assets surfaced when adults shifted from labeling to invitation: *Student M* contributed as a helper in E1, and in E2 an adult explicitly repositioned a student as capable and needed—“*You’re smart, you can help them.*”

Evidence Set E2 also contains language that names cognitive diversity as strength rather than pathology: “There’s never just one way to solve a problem when you’re coding. There’s always multiple ways to figure it out, and the way that you guys think differently is a strength.” That statement matters because it names neurodivergent brilliance as real and worth organizing learning around—not as something to be managed or corrected.

For CLD students, assets are also linguistic. The professional learning discussion (E4) surfaced the practice of inviting students to explain ideas “in their own language” as an equity move in computer science education. Paris and Alim’s (2014) culturally sustaining pedagogy provides the theoretical grounding: when schooling treats only one language variety and one participation style as legitimate, it erases communicative strength rather than building on it. hooks (1994) names this as engaged pedagogy—staying genuinely curious about the whole person underneath the behavior and building conditions where students can participate without being required to abandon who they are.

Implications for Future Practice

These observations change what I want to do before I assign a label to a student. Talusan (2022) argues that identity-conscious practice is built from repeatable habits—not grand gestures, but daily routines of noticing and questioning. The three commitments below are habits I can rehearse in real time.

Treat escalation as information, not defiance. When a student is yelling, shut down, or talking out of turn, my first questions should be contextual: What is this student trying to communicate? What is the trigger? What would make participation possible in the next two minutes? This is aligned with Flynn’s (2024) affirmative orientation: difficulty is real, but the appropriate response is support and dignity—not tragedy framing and behavioral control.

Lead with relationship and co-regulation. In E1 and E3, purposeful roles, patience, and competence-narrating language enabled re-entry into learning. Those are not supplementary moves—they are the lesson plan.

Practice linguistic justice as classroom management. If schools reward “respect” primarily as silence, speed, and standardized speech, then CLD and neurodivergent students are structurally set up to be misread (E4; Paris & Alim, 2014). As I wrote to my future teacher-self (J2), the fear is not structure itself—it is structure deployed to purchase adult comfort through compliance. The goal is participation norms that are explicitly taught, designed for learning, and still firm and humane.

Undergirding all three commitments is a commitment to auditing my own language and interpretations (Annamma et al., 2013; Nieto, 2004): Am I labeling a student, or describing conditions and identifying supports? hooks (1994) keeps the ethical center visible—scaffold before shaming, narrate competence before deficit, and design participation structures that make room for more than one way of being a learner.

Conclusion

This paper began with a bias that travels invisibly into classroom practice: the reflex to read behavioral and communicative difference as evidence of fixed student character. Practicum observation gave me evidence to interrupt that reflex.

Across the four evidence sets, I watched how quickly a student can be produced as a “*problem*” through adult interpretation—and how quickly that category loosens when adults respond relationally. When adults shifted from public control to co-regulation and competence-talk, participation became possible again (E1–E3). The linguistic justice lens sharpened the stakes for CLD students (E4): When schools treat silence, speed, and standardized speech as the only legitimate ways to learn, difference does not merely go unrecognized. It becomes punishable.

Going forward, my commitment is to make the interpretive pause into pedagogy: read behavior as communication, design conditions that widen participation, and use structure to support learning rather than to purchase compliance. In my own words, I want it to be less likely that another CLD, neurodivergent kid slips through cracks that were never accidents (J2).

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